

Gov. and Politics of Japan - Subject: Japan's Political Reinvention

Modern Japan was shaped by two critical moments of state transformation that set the stage for the country; the Meiji “invention” of Japan in the late nineteenth century and the postwar “reinvention” of the state after World War II. Though each transformation had its own set of circumstances, both emerged from Japan's need for political reform. Japan's Meiji invention and postwar reinvention were not ideological revolutions but necessary responses to domestic collapse and international pressure, as the postwar constitution orders built on the foundation that Meiji-era institutions provided.

First, when examining the Meiji period, it was historically necessary for Japan to be “invented” due to the failing ability of the Tokugawa regime to protect sovereignty from international pressure and internal turmoil. Domestically, the Tokugawa era closed off Japan from the world and caused industrial progress to come to a halt. The shogunate of Japan was weak, paving the way for the Meiji restoration to dramatically change the entire political scheme. Under the slogan of “Rich Country, Strong Military”, the Meiji period “socialized citizens for Westernization, industrialization, and empire building” (Dower, *Peace and Democracy*). Guided by this ideal, Japan centralized authority and economically progressed to compete with the West, transforming “from a weak agrarian society to an industrial powerhouse” (Freeman, *Lecture*). Internationally, Japan's “seclusion was ruptured by the Western nations in 1853” (Dower, *Peace and Democracy*), as the arrival of gunboats and unequal treaties revealed the Tokugawa state's vulnerability to modern threats. Without rapid modernization, Japan risked political fragmentation and subordination to foreign powers, as had occurred elsewhere in Asia.

Similar to the pressures that led to the collapse of Tokugawa rule, Japan's defeat in World War II made it necessary for a "reinvention" during the Occupation, as it shattered the legitimacy of the Meiji political system. In analyzing the domestic issues, the imperial system that had already justified the country's expansion no longer held any authority. This collapse created a political vacuum in which fundamental change was necessary, as "destruction of the militarized state was essential to democratize Japan, and only the creation of a genuinely democratic nation could prevent the danger of future Japanese militarism" (Dower, *Peace and Democracy*). The army's abolition and the rewriting of the constitution reflected the thought that Japan's prewar order was incompatible with new, democratic principles. The international pressures were equally decisive in controlling the occupation of Japan, as the reinvention occurred within the framework of the emerging Cold War. By incorporating Japan into a U.S.-led security order in East Asia, the United States created a system that "defined the strategic status quo in the Asia-Pacific area since the early 1950s" (Dower, *The San Francisco System*). Under this system, Japan regained formal sovereignty, even as it accepted limits on its foreign policy. Further illustrated in lecture, the Occupation represented a broader exercise of American power, as the United States aimed to use Japan "to right the Asian world and as a bulwark against communism" (Freeman, Lecture). In this way, Japan's postwar reinvention reduced the country from a potential threat to a decisive and controlled force.

When examined together, both the Meiji and postwar reforms were fundamentally strategic and defensive rather than ideological, as elites in each period pursued reform to secure Japan's success under hostile conditions, although for different reasons. During the Meiji period, the reform was driven by competition within an industrialized world order dominated by Western powers. Meiji leaders had pursued modernization not to expand sovereignty but to ensure that

Japan would be recognized as a global equal. The Meiji reform was thus framed as a calculated strategy of state-building, focusing on building Japan's status. The postwar reform followed a similar logic that stressed the defense of Japan, but differed due to heavy imposition from the United States. In the face of political collapse, Western reform was accepted as a necessary condition for the country's survival. As Buruma notes, "occupied Japan continued to be run officially by Japanese governments under the autocratic gaze of SCAP" (Buruma, *Inventing Japan* 132). Although Japanese institutions formally remained, authority rested with the United States, which dictated the scope and content of reform. This imposed nature distinguishes postwar reinvention from Meiji reform, even though both moments reveal a consistent logic in which elites reshaped the state in response to pressure rather than ideological commitments.

Moving forward, these two reforms produced different constitutional outcomes, marked by both continuity and rupture between the Meiji and postwar orders. The most significant rupture between the two constitutional orders was the redefinition of sovereignty under the postwar constitution. The Meiji Constitution located political authority and created a system in which power was exercised by Japanese elites. However, after the defeat, constitutional reform occurred under foreign authority and not domestic powers. As observed, the "Japanese knew that SCAP was the ruler now, not Hirohito, who was under the general's protection" (Buruma, *Inventing Japan*), capturing the difference in sovereignty between the Meiji and postwar orders. On the other hand, a major continuity between the Meiji and the postwar orders was the retention of the imperial institution and the basic framework of the state. Although the new constitution redefined the Emperor as a symbol rather than a sovereign, the survival of the monarchy represented a bridge to the Meiji past. The reformers "scooped the old Meiji Constitution hollow" and then filled the shell "with Anglo-American and European democratic ideals"

(Dower, *Embracing Defeat*). This suggests that while Japanese laws were rewritten with Western ideals, the underlying structural foundation of the Japanese state remained a direct legacy of the Meiji system.

In conclusion, while Japan's two state transformations differed in their conditions, both had significant implications for Japan's political order as a nation. In both moments, domestic and international pressures led the country to pursue reforms that adapted state power to a charged global environment.

Works Cited

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